

Platecarpus

PLAH-teh-CAR-pus

- **When** 85–80 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 14 ft (4.2 m)

Platecarpus was not the largest mosasaur but it was certainly was one of the most abundant. Its fossils have been found worldwide, most commonly in the Niobrara chalk beds of

North America. Like other mosasaurs, *Platecarpus* used its long, muscular tail to drive itself through water in a zigzag, snakelike manner. It had fewer and smaller teeth than other mosasaurs, suggesting a diet of softer prey such as fish and squid. The belly of one specimen was found to contain fish scales and fish bones—the remains of one of its last meals.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Lizardlike bodies with flippers
- Powerful jaws lined with sharp teeth
- Breathed air at the water surface

When

Mosasaurs lived in the Cretaceous Period, between 85 and 65 million years ago. They were killed along with dinosaurs and most other large reptiles in the mass extinction at the end of the Period.



In the Cretaceous, an ocean ran down the middle of North America, cutting the continent in two. Its muddy bed has now turned to rock, forming the Niobrara chalk of North America. Niobrara chalk contains a wealth of amazing fossils, including mosasaurs and plesiosaurs.